

The final match of the 2026 FIFA World Cup, the 23rd edition of FIFA's competition for national soccer teams, was played at MetLife Stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey, part of the New York metropolitan area, on July 19, 2026, and was contested by Spain and defending champions Argentina.

The tournament was contested by hosts United States, Mexico, and Canada, and 45 other teams who emerged from the qualification phase, which was organized by the six FIFA confederations. The 48 teams competed in a group stage, from which 32 teams qualified for the knockout stage. En route to the final, Spain finished first in Group H with two wins and a draw, before defeating Austria in the round of 32, Portugal in the round of 16, Belgium in the quarterfinal, and France in the semifinal. Argentina finished first in Group J with three wins, after which they defeated Cape Verde in the round of 32, Egypt in the round of 16, Switzerland in the quarterfinal, and England in the semifinal. The final took place in front of 80,663 spectators, and was refereed by Slavko Vinčič of Slovenia.

Lamine Yamal had a chance to score for Spain early in the first half when he hit a curl shot, which was saved by Argentina's goalkeeper Emiliano Martínez, and Marc Cucurella had an opportunity to score shortly before half-time but his shot went wide of the goal. In the second half, Ferran Torres had a chance when he met with a header, but his shot was denied by Martínez. Before the end of regulation time, Argentina midfielder Enzo Fernández received a second yellow card for a challenge against Pau Cubarsí and was sent off; shortly afterwards, Yamal took a free kick, but his shot was saved by Martínez. With the match goalless after 90 minutes—and with Argentina becoming the first team in a World Cup final to register no shots in regulation time—the game went into extra time, in the second period of which Spain broke the deadlock. Torres, who had come on as a substitute, received the ball from a header by Nico Williams and kicked it with a left-footed shot to secure a 1–0 victory for Spain. After the final whistle, a brawl broke out, in which multiple Argentina players were involved.

Spain's win was their second World Cup title and the first since 2010, becoming the first

country to simultaneously hold the men's and women's World Cup titles, having won the latter in 2023. Torres was named the man of the match. The match saw the most saves ever in a World Cup final, with 11 by Argentina goalkeeper Emiliano Martínez. The match was preceded by the closing ceremony. The match was the first ever World Cup final to include a halftime show, which caused the full halftime break to last over 27 minutes, against International Football Association Board (IFAB) protocol.

Background

The 2026 FIFA World Cup was the 23rd edition of the World Cup, FIFA's soccer competition for national teams, held in Canada, Mexico and the United States between June 11 and July 19, 2026. The national teams of Canada, Mexico, and the United States automatically qualified for the tournament as hosts, while 206 teams competed for the remaining 45 slots through qualifying rounds organized by the six FIFA confederations and held between September 2023 and March 2026. The tournament featured 48 teams for the first time, up from 32 in the 2022 World Cup. The teams were divided into twelve groups of four, with each team playing every other team once in a round-robin format. The top two teams from each group, alongside the eight highest-ranked third-place teams, advanced to the knockout stage.

Spain had won the World Cup once before, defeating the Netherlands in the 2010 final in Johannesburg, South Africa. Spain was the reigning UEFA European champion, having won its fourth title in 2024. Entering the 2026 final, Spain was tied with Italy for the longest undefeated streak in the history of men's international soccer, with 37 matches. Argentina was the defending World Cup champion, having won the 2022 tournament; it had also won the title in 1978 and 1986. Argentina was also the reigning Copa América champion, having won its 16th title in 2024.

Spain and Argentina had played each other fourteen times since 1952, with each team winning six matches. They had previously played one World Cup match, in the group stage of

the 1966 tournament, which Argentina won 2–1. Their most recent meeting before the 2026 World Cup was a friendly match in Madrid on March 27, 2018, which Spain won 6–1. Spain and Argentina were originally scheduled to meet at the 2026 Finalissima in Qatar in March 2026, but the match was cancelled due to the Iran war.

The 2026 final was the first time in the tournament's history to feature two reigning continental champions, who were the two top-ranked teams in the FIFA World Ranking. It was also the second that two Spanish-speaking countries competed against each other, after Uruguay and Argentina contested the inaugural 1930 final. The official match ball, used in the semifinals, match for third place, and the final, was announced on July 6, 2026. It was a variation of the Adidas Trionda named the Trionda Final. While the technical specifications remain the same, it had a special design with a gold, white, and black color scheme that resembles the FIFA World Cup Trophy.

Venue

Stadium

The final was played at MetLife Stadium, temporarily renamed New York New Jersey Stadium for the World Cup, in East Rutherford, New Jersey, 5 miles (8.0 km) west of New York City. Over the tournament, the stadium hosted seven other matches, including five group stage matches, a round of 32 match, and a round of 16 match. MetLife Stadium, previously known as New Meadowlands Stadium until 2011, opened in 2010 and has a listed capacity of 82,500 seats. It is home to the New York Giants and New York Jets of the National Football League (NFL) and had previously hosted Super Bowl XLVIII in 2014, the Copa América Centenario final in 2016, and the 2025 FIFA Club World Cup final.

MetLife Stadium was proposed as the ideal final venue in the United 2026 bid, which was selected on June 13, 2018. The stadium was announced as the final venue in February 2024. The New Jersey Sports and Exposition Authority (NJSEA), which oversees MetLife Stadium,

approved a \$15.9 million contract to expand MetLife Stadium in June 2023, which was done to meet FIFA's size requirements. In preparation for the World Cup, the stadium went under renovations in January 2024. Work was divided into two phases, completed in May 2024 and May 2025, during the NFL offseason. A total of 1,740 seats in the lower bowl corners were removed to widen the field; several sections of removable bleacher seating were then installed for NFL games. In May 2026, a Bermuda grass surface, sourced from North Carolina, was temporarily laid over the field's normal artificial turf for the tournament. The grass was originally supposed to be sourced from New Jersey. The pitch was later criticized by players, including Vinícius Júnior and Adrien Rabiot, with them describing it as "dry and difficult", while visible worn patches were noted by the media.

During the tournament, the Meadowlands Rail Line, a shuttle train with no regular service, and a new \$35 million busway were planned to be used to transport attendees from the nearest transit hub at Secaucus Junction. In April 2026, NJ Transit, which operates the Meadowlands Rail Line, announced that \$150 tickets would be issued for the train service, with dedicated queues at New York Penn Station, and \$80 fares for express buses. These costs, higher than the usual \$12.90 train fare for MetLife Stadium services, were announced to offset the \$48 million cost of providing event service and security that was not subsidized by FIFA and other grants. In May 2026, NJ Transit announced that sponsorships and other funds raised would allow train fares to be reduced to \$105 and later to \$98.

Host selection

In August 2017, the United Bid Committee listed MetLife Stadium as among the 37 stadiums for consideration as potential host venues. After the selection of the United 2026 bid in June 2018, MetLife Stadium was considered an early frontrunner to host the final, due to its proximity to New York City and experience of hosting major sporting events. As a part of FIFA's Candidate Host City tour for the World Cup, MetLife Stadium and its facilities were

visited by FIFA representatives in September 2021. That year, a joint bid—formed by New York and New Jersey—was submitted for MetLife Stadium to host multiple matches during the World Cup. In June 2022, the stadium was announced as among of the sixteen host venues, including its competitor SoFi Stadium, a newer stadium in Inglewood, California, near Los Angeles. The Rose Bowl in Pasadena, California, the Los Angeles area venue that hosted the 1994 men's final and 1999 women's final, was not chosen for the tournament due to its age. SoFi Stadium was designed primarily for American football with a field that is 69 yards (63 m) wide—narrower than FIFA's recommended dimensions. According to media reports, the stadium's owner, Kroenke Sports & Entertainment, was also unhappy with the revenue-sharing deal proposed by FIFA and threatened to cancel their plans to host World Cup matches. In early 2023, AT&T Stadium in the Dallas area emerged as a potential host for the final due to its higher capacity of 90,000 seats and scheduled renovations to accommodate a wider field. According to The Athletic, the selection of MetLife Stadium came as a "surprise" to local officials, who organized a small viewing party for the announcement. Dallas's bid had been favored—and rumored as the winner in January—and included a simulcast of the match at two nearby venues to increase ticket revenue.

Route to the final

Spain

Spain entered the 2026 World Cup as a favorite to win the tournament, and qualified after securing first place in their qualification group. They were drawn into Group H, alongside Cape Verde, Saudi Arabia, and Uruguay. Their first match was against World Cup debutants Cape Verde on June 15 at Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta; the game ended in a 0–0 draw, due to a strong defensive performance from Cape Verde and their goalkeeper, Vozinha. Their second match was against Saudi Arabia in Atlanta on June 21. Spain took the lead early when Mikel Oyarzabal crossed from the left and Lamine Yamal scored from close range. This was followed

by a corner kick for Spain, which Oyarzabal scored to double their lead in the 21st minute. Three minutes later, Oyarzabal scored his second from close range to give Spain a 3–0 lead. In the second half, Marc Cucurella took the kick from the corner, in which Saudi Arabia's goalkeeper Hassan Tambakti saved the ball, but it deflected off Hassan Al Tambakti into the goal for an own goal, which secured Spain a 4–0 victory. Spain finished atop Group H with seven points after a 1–0 win over Uruguay in their third match, played June 26 at Estadio Akron near Guadalajara, with a goal from Álex Baena minutes before halftime.

As group winners, Spain played Group J runners-up Austria in the round of 32 on July 2 at SoFi Stadium in the Los Angeles area. The team won 3–0 with a pair of goals from Oyarzabal and a header by right-back Pedro Porro to beat Austria goalkeeper Alexander Schlager, who made several key saves in the first half. The performance, described as "dominant" by BBC Sport, was Spain's first win in a World Cup knockout stage since the 2010 final. The team advanced to the round of 16 to play Portugal on July 6 at AT&T Stadium near Dallas. The Spanish attack were given few clear chances to score, but won 1–0 with a stoppage time goal from substitute Mikel Merino. Spain returned to the Los Angeles area for the quarterfinal against Belgium on July 10. The two sides exchanged goals in the first half, with Fabián Ruiz giving Spain the lead in the 30th minute through a rebound off goalkeeper Thibaut Courtois and Belgium's Charles De Ketelaere equalizing with a header in the 41st minute. Courtois made several saves but left the match with an injury in the second half; his replacement, Senne Lammens, was unable to recover a rebound that fell to Merino's feet to score in the 88th minute and earn a 2–1 victory.

In the semifinals, Spain faced another tournament favorite, France, on July 14 in Dallas; France had outscored opponents 16–2 in their previous six matches and maintained clean sheets in four matches. By the semifinal, the team had traveled over 12,000 miles (19,000 km) between its base camp in Chattanooga, Tennessee, and matches played in Mexico and the United States. Spain's strong defensive performance, led by Rodri in the midfield, withstood France's

attack and produced openings that were exploited. A penalty kick won by Lamine Yamal was converted by Oyarzabal in the 22nd minute and was followed by a one-two play with Dani Olmo to Pedro Porro to score in the 58th minute. Spain won 2–0 and booked their place in the final.

Argentina

Argentina entered the tournament also as one of the favorites to win, and earned their World Cup slot by placing first in South American qualifiers. They were drawn into Group J, alongside Algeria, Austria, and Jordan. Their first match was against Algeria on June 16 at Arrowhead Stadium in Kansas City, near Argentina's base camp. Argentina won 3–0 through a hat trick by Lionel Messi, who equaled the record for most World Cup goals. In their second match against Austria on June 22 at AT&T Stadium near Dallas, Messi scored twice and the team won 2–0. Argentina finished atop the group with nine points after a 3–1 win against World Cup debutants Jordan on June 27 in Atlanta. Giovanni Lo Celso scored the opening goal in the 19th minute to give Argentina the lead, which was followed by a penalty that was converted by Lautaro Martínez. Musa Al-Taamari scored for Jordan to break the shutout, but Messi entered the match as a substitute and scored from a free kick in the 80th minute.

As group winners, Argentina played Group H runners-up Cape Verde in the round of 32 on July 3 at Hard Rock Stadium near Miami. Messi opened the scoring in the 29th minute from close range, but a run and finish by Deroy Duarte allowed Cape Verde to equalize in the second half. The match remained tied and went to extra time, where Lisandro Martínez put Argentina in the lead within two minutes. Sidney Lopes Cabral equalized for Cape Verde with a curling shot that beat Emiliano Martínez in the 103rd minute, but was followed by an own goal off the arm of Diney Borges on a corner kick to give Argentina a 3–2 victory. In the round of 16 on July 7, Argentina faced Egypt in Atlanta and conceded two goals to Yasser Ibrahim and Mostafa Ziko. Messi had an earlier penalty kick saved, but provided an assist to Cristian Romero's header

before scoring himself to tie the match in the 83rd minute. Argentina won 3–2 with a header from Enzo Fernández in the second minute of stoppage time amid controversy over a disallowed goal and penalty by the referee.

The team returned to Kansas City for their quarterfinal match against Switzerland on July 11, played in hot and humid conditions. Alexis Mac Allister scored with a header in the 10th minute to give Argentina the lead, but the match was tied in the 67th minute by Dan Ndoye. Switzerland lost Breel Embolo five minutes later to a red card after the video assistant referee determined there was a case of mistaken identity for another foul, which resulted in a second yellow card. Argentina eventually won 3–1 in extra time through a long-distance strike by Julián Álvarez and a rebound from Lautaro Martínez. Argentina advanced to the semifinal on July 15 in Atlanta, where they faced England, a longtime rival in the World Cup. After Anthony Gordon goal in the 55th minute gave England the lead, head coach Thomas Tuchel switched to a five-defender formation with several substitutions. Messi provided assists for the equalizer in the 86th minute by Enzo Fernández and Lautaro Martínez's winning header in the second minute of stoppage time. Argentina won 2–1 to reach their second consecutive World Cup final.

Entertainment

Closing ceremony

A closing ceremony for the World Cup began at 1:40 p.m. Eastern Daylight Time (UTC-4), eighty minutes before the scheduled kickoff. IShowSpeed performed his World Cup-themed song "Champions", while headliner Post Malone and rapper Swae Lee sang "Sunflower". Afterwards, Jennifer Hudson sang "The Star-Spangled Banner", the national anthem of the United States, with Robbie Williams, Nicole Scherzinger and Laura Pausini then performing the song "Desire". Mario Kempes and Andres Iniesta, two respective members of Argentina's and

Spain's winning teams in 1978 and 2010, unveiled the FIFA World Cup Trophy. Spain's national anthem was performed by the Spanish brass quintet Spanish Brass, while Argentine singer María Becerra sang Argentina's national anthem.

Halftime show

The 2026 final was the first to feature a halftime show, similar to those in the NFL's Super Bowl. The show was announced by FIFA on November 28, 2024, with Global Citizen listed as the co-producer. It was curated by Chris Martin of Coldplay. The performance also aimed to raise \$100 million for the FIFA Global Citizen Education Fund. The show was headlined by Madonna, Shakira, Justin Bieber and BTS. It also included guest performances by Gustavo Dudamel, New York Philharmonic, Simón Bolívar Symphony Orchestra, Bijan Mortazavi, Electric Mayhem, Burna Boy, Ghetto Kids, The Muppets, Emmanuel Kelly and PS22 Chorus, as well as guest appearances by Jason Sudeikis and Brendan Hunt as their characters from the television series Ted Lasso.

The halftime show was criticized by commentators and fans as being too commercialized and an unwanted Americanization of the match. The halftime break lasted 27 minutes and 22 seconds, which broke the IFAB Laws of the Game which state that the halftime break cannot exceed 15 minutes. On the BBC live broadcast of the match, Wayne Rooney said of the halftime show, "It was crap."

Pre-match

On July 16, 2026, Slavko Vinčič, from Slovenia, was named as the referee of the final, together with fellow Slovenes Tomaž Klančnik and Andraž Kovačič as assistant referees and Adham Makhadmeh and Mohammad Al-Kalaf from Jordan as the fourth official and reserve assistant referee. The VAR team consisted of Bastian Dankert, Nicolas Gallo, and Khamis Al-Marri. Tatiana Guzman and Guillermo Pacheco served as standby VARs. Earlier in the tournament,

Vinčić officiated the Brazil–Morocco and Jordan–Algeria matches in the group stage and the Mexico–Ecuador match in the round of 32. He had previously taken charge of the 2022 UEFA Europa League final and 2024 UEFA Champions League final. He also was one of the referees at the UEFA Euro 2020, 2022 World Cup, UEFA Euro 2024, and 2025 FIFA Club World Cup. He became the first Slovenian to referee a World Cup final.

Dignitaries in attendance

US president Donald Trump attended the match and later presented the trophy to the winning team, which received 30 championship rings similar to those used by North American sports leagues. King of Spain Felipe VI, Queen Letizia, with Leonor, Princess of Asturias, Infanta Sofía and Spanish prime minister Pedro Sánchez attended the match to watch their country's national team in the final. Citing his superstitious beliefs, Argentine president Javier Milei declined to attend. Mexican president Claudia Sheinbaum and Canadian prime minister Mark Carney, representing the two other co-hosts, attended the final after being invited by Trump. Although UEFA President Aleksander Čeferin attended the tournament's June 11, opening match in Mexico City, he boycotted the final after a dispute with FIFA over a suspended disciplinary ban issued to United States player Folarin Balogun. Čeferin, representing the European confederation of which Spain is a member, criticized FIFA's decision to defer Balogun's automatic suspension after he received a red card during a round of 32 match against Bosnia and Herzegovina, which the United States won 2–0. In contrast, CONMEBOL President Alejandro Domínguez attended the final to support Argentina alongside Argentine Football Association (AFA) President Claudio Tapia. Rafael Louzán, President of the Royal Spanish Football Federation (RFEF), also attended the match.

Match

Summary

First half

Argentina kicked off the match at 3:06 p.m. EDT (7:06 p.m. UTC) in temperatures of 80 °F (27 °C) with 40% humidity, in front of a crowd of 80,663. The weather at Teterboro Airport, 4.4 mi (7.1 km) from the stadium, was recorded as fair before kick-off. Spain had a chance five minutes in the game when Lamine Yamal passed the ball to Dani Olmo, who returned it back to him. Yamal took the shot, which deflected off Lisandro Martinez's foot, and Argentina's goalkeeper Emiliano Martínez, who moved toward his right, aligned his foot to save it. Then, Spain's goalkeeper Unai Simon ran 40 yards from goal to kick the ball away from Lionel Messi, which lands toward Julián Alvarez, who struggles to control it. On fourteen minutes, Alexis Mac Allister fouled Dani Olmo during a tackle, in which the referee denied giving a yellow card. Two minutes later, Yamal hit a curl shot toward the goal, but the ball landed softly in Martínez's hands. On 39 minutes, Mikel Oyarzabal hit a 20-yard (18 m) low shot from a long-range effort, which was saved by Martínez once again. On 41 minutes, Lisandro Martinez was booked for a foul on Oyarzabal. After this play, Argentina was forced to make a substitution when Lisandro Martínez was injured and was unable to continue; he was replaced by Nicolás Otamendi in the 44th minute.

Second half

At the start of the second half, Spain capitalized on an Argentine buildup error, with the ball falling to Alex Baena, whose shot was saved by Martínez just one minute in, in the 46th. Spain continued to press, and in the 53rd minute, Fabián Ruiz tried a collective play with Oyarzabal in search of a chance, which did not materialize. A minute later, Dani Olmo attempted a cross looking for Cucurella, but Gonzalo Montiel intervened to prevent the ball from reaching him. The clearest chance in the second half came in the 66th minute, when Yamal drove down the right flank to the byline and delivered a cross that Ferran Torres met with a header, but Martínez held onto it.

The closing minutes of the second half were dominated by Spain, with more crucial saves from Martínez. In the 76th minute, he denied a shot from Pedri, and a minute later he did the same to stop an effort from Pau Cubarsí. In the 80th minute, Nico Williams got to the byline and sent in a cross that Aymeric Laporte rose to meet with a header, only for it to end up safely in Martínez's hands.

Argentina had their first real chance of the match in the 3rd minute of added time, when Giuliano Simeone hit a low cross from the right, but Unai Simón intercepted the ball with ease. On the resulting counterattack, Williams carried the ball for 30 meters before taking a powerful shot from the edge of the box, which was also saved by Martínez. A few seconds later, Argentina lost one player after Enzo Fernández was sent off for a second yellow card, when his attempt to win a loose ball resulted in a reckless challenge against Cubarsí.

In the final seconds of regular time, Yamal struck a free kick that Martínez managed to deflect away, sending the match into extra time. With the expiration of regular time, Argentina became the first team to fail to register a shot during the 90 minutes of a World Cup final.

Extra time

In the 93rd minute, Williams was not able to head a Pedri cross with enough power, and Martínez dove to his right to make the save. Three minutes later, Williams appeared to score, after the ball fell to him following a play done by Merino, but the goal was disallowed because Merino had stepped on Otamendi's foot. Merino then headed a chance wide of Martínez's goal in the 102nd minute. At the start of the second period of extra time, Torres received a ball headed down back by Williams, and struck it powerfully with his left foot from close range to beat Martínez, putting Spain in the lead, 1-0.

After the goal, Argentina began to press in search of an equalizer, which led to counterattacking chances. In the 113th minute, Torres went in front of goal against Martínez and appeared to score his second goal, but it was ruled out for offside. Two minutes later,

Messi attempted to catch Simón off guard with a cross from the attacking third that drifted toward the Spanish goal, passing over the crossbar. In the 116th minute, Williams created another opportunity and found himself in a favorable position inside Argentina's box after outrunning Nahuel Molina, but was unable to connect with the ball to shoot or find a teammate to extend Spain's lead. In the 117th minute, Messi's shot from the edge of the box, Argentina's first of the match, struck Merino in the face as the midfielder blocked it, leaving him down on the pitch as the match entered its final minutes.

In the 120th minute, Argentina's final buildup came from a Simeone pass toward Marcos Senesi in the box, but Cubarsí cleared the danger for a corner. The resulting corner kick led to a scramble inside the goal area, with the Spanish defense kicking the ball out of bounds. The next corner was deflected by Nicolás Tagliafico on the near post and fell to Simeone's feet, but his desperate attempt from close to the penalty spot went well over the bar. In the final minutes, Spain kept possession away from their own goal, while a long free kick from Martínez was comfortably dealt with by the Spanish defense before the final whistle confirmed Spain's title.

Details

Statistics

Post-match

Following the match, Yamal and Messi embraced and exchanged words, a moment described by FIFA and several media outlets as symbolic of a generational transition in football, with Messi approaching the end of an illustrious career and Yamal, regarded as one of the sport's most promising talents, at the start of his. The encounter drew additional resonance from a 2007 photograph in which Messi, then 20 years old, bathed the infant Yamal during a charity photo session while in FC Barcelona, an image that had attracted renewed media attention in the context of their meeting on the pitch nearly two decades later.

Spain's Ferran Torres, who scored the only goal of the final, was named as the man of the match. In the awards ceremony after the match, Spain's Rodri was named as the Golden Ball winner as the best player of the tournament, while teammate Unai Simón won the Golden Glove as the best goalkeeper of the World Cup. Compatriot Pau Cubarsí won the FIFA Young Player Award as the best young player of the tournament. Messi won the Silver Ball as the second-best player of the tournament, while also securing the Silver Boot with eight goals in the tournament (only behind the ten of Kylian Mbappé).

FIFA president Gianni Infantino and US president Donald Trump presented the trophy to captain Rodri; both Infantino and Trump were booed by many of the fans in attendance. Trump spoke briefly with Rodri and several other Spanish players on the podium, who appeared eager to lift the trophy, but then delayed doing so while he remained with the team. Infantino attempted to lead Trump out of the way of the trophy lift, but he initially insisted on remaining alongside the players, before eventually stepping aside, positioning himself at the edge of the victory photograph.

Spain became the first country to simultaneously win both the men's and women's World Cups, having won the latter in 2023, and became the first team to win the FIFA World Cup immediately after winning the Olympic gold medal since Italy in 1936 and 1938. Argentina's Lionel Messi became the second player in history to play in a World Cup final for the third time, after Brazil's Cafu had done so in 2002. The final also featured eleven saves by goalkeeper Martínez, the most ever recorded in a World Cup final.

Altercations between players

After the match concluded, multiple altercations broke out between Argentina's and Spain's players. Argentina's defender Nahuel Molina was seen striking Spain's captain Rodri in the stomach, who was running to celebrate their team's victory. Rodri instantly turned back around to confront him, in which Eric García spotted them and ran over to stop them. Shortly

after, Leandro Paredes tackled García, who fell to the ground, resulting in a physical altercation. Just as he was getting up, Paredes shoved him by the throat, and shortly after, Argentina's coaching staff protected García from him. Paredes then wrestled Gavi to the ground, with substitute Thiago Almada getting involved as he ripped his training bib. Simultaneously, Argentina's assistant coach Roberto Ayala grabbed Spain's Dani Olmo by the bib before punching him in the face. Multiple media outlets reported that Paredes was shown a red card after the incident, but the red card did not appear in FIFA's official match report results.

The actions of the Argentinian side after the end of the match were described as a "disgrace to football" by several international media outlets. Paredes was criticized for his violent behavior during and after the match, and Messi was also criticized for attempting to have Marc Cucurella sent off for briefly covering his mouth after Fernández' red card. Some media outlets called Spain's victory a "victory for football". FIFA announced an investigation in the behavior of the Argentinian players and staff, including Paredes, Molina and Ayala. In the days that followed the teams toned the scuffle down, with Ayala apologizing and Gavi speaking against possible suspensions for his rivals.

Aftermath and reactions

The referee's decision to rule out Williams' goal in the 96th minute, stemming from a foul by Merino who stepped on Otamendi's foot during the build-up, provoked mixed reactions. Several fans and players noted that the contact was minor and of a nature that referees sometimes overlook in the penalty area, and highlighted that Otamendi had his arm around Merino prior to the incident. During the match, Spain supporters sarcastically chanted "Infantino" following the disallowed goal, referencing allegations of FIFA favoring Argentina. Celebrations broke out among supporters across various parts of Spain. In Ciudad Rodrigo, Salamanca, a 13-year-old died and three others were injured when the fountain at the Glorieta

del Árbol Gordo collapsed over them. A 20-year-old also died in Sonseca during what was reported as a convulsion. Across Spain that evening, more than 80 people were reported injured and approximately 12 arrested. In New York City, celebrations broke out in several parts of the city, including Times Square, Central Park, and Little Spain, Manhattan. In Mexico City, where there is a large Spaniard community, several Spain supporters and Mexico national team fans celebrated at the Fountain of Cybele.

In Buenos Aires, fans and government officials gathered at Ezeiza International Airport to receive the national team, where the Argentine Armed Forces performed an orchestra rendition of the football chant *Muchachos, ahora nos volvimos a ilusionar* (transl. Guys, we have our hopes up again) and a drone show marked their arrival. Messi and several other players did not travel to Buenos Aires, instead flying directly to their club destinations or to begin their holidays. The arriving players were transported through the city on an open-top bus, greeted by large crowds and fireworks along the route. Thousands of additional supporters gathered at the Obelisk. The celebrations were marred by riots in which supporters threw stones, glass bottles, and other objects at police. Riot police responded with water cannons, tear gas, and rubber bullets to disperse the crowds. Local police reported at least fifteen arrests and several injuries during the clashes.

The Spain national team returned to Madrid the next day and was welcomed at the Madrid-Barajas Airport. The World Cup victory parade happened at 7:00 pm CEST (UTC+2) through central Madrid, where the attendance was expected to be over a million, although the number ended up being closer to two million. The parade concluded at Plaza de Cibeles, where the Spanish team did a trophy lift in front of a large crowd.

See also

[Argentina at the FIFA World Cup](#)

[Spain at the FIFA World Cup](#)

1994 FIFA World Cup final – another World Cup final played in the United States

Notes

References

Reports

External links

2026 FIFA World Cup official website